

GUIDE

Athlete legacy: *do you need a foundation?*

A clear-eyed guide for athletes, agents and advisers on building a legacy that outlasts a career. With the Legacy Readiness Score.

purpose before paperwork

FOR ATHLETES, AGENTS AND ADVISERS

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A foundation is one answer. It is not the question.

Somewhere near the peak of a sporting career, someone suggests a foundation. It will carry your name, do good in your sport or your home town, and give the money and attention somewhere to go. Sometimes that is exactly right. Often it is the most expensive way to do something simpler.

INTERPRETATION The pattern we see is consistent. The foundation is set up quickly, named after the athlete, with family and the agent as trustees. Its income is the athlete's own money and one annual dinner. It does good, visible work for two or three seasons. Then the career ends, the invitations slow, the dinner raises less than it costs, and the trustees find themselves filing accounts for a charity that has quietly stopped. Nobody meant it to go that way. It went that way because the paperwork came before the purpose.

This guide puts the questions in the right order. What legacy do you want? Who is it for? Which vehicle fits it: a gift, a named fund, a partnership, or a charity of your own? If a charity, how do you govern and fund it so that it outlives your playing days? And how do you prove it made a difference? It ends with the Legacy Readiness Score: ten questions, twenty points, and a reading of what to do next.

Throughout, we label statements the way we do in our client work:

EVIDENCE a fact from the law, the regulator or HMRC **INTERPRETATION** our reading of what it means for you
DECISION a choice only you can make

THE ONE-SENTENCE VERSION

Decide what you want to change and for whom, prove it with something small, and only then choose the structure. Legacy is built by intentional action and authentic impact, not by a registration number.

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How do you want to be remembered, and by whom?

Your legacy is not your medal count. It is what is different, for other people, because you were here. Clarify that before anyone drafts a constitution.

Athletes' legacies tend to take one of three shapes. Most people feel the pull of one more than the others, and knowing which saves years of drift.

A CAUSE

A problem you have lived with or seen up close: a condition, an injustice, a group of people who get overlooked. The legacy is progress on that problem, and your sport is the platform, not the subject.

A PLACE

The town, the estate, the club or the school that made you. The legacy is that place being better for the next kid in your position. Local, specific, and usually best delivered with partners who are already there.

THE NEXT GENERATION

Your sport, and the people coming through it: access, coaching, pathways, the talent that never gets seen. The legacy is in the pathway itself, often in partnership with a club or governing body.

Reflect on values first

INTERPRETATION Values are what you would still do if nobody was watching. An athlete who says "I want to give back" has a feeling, not a legacy. An athlete who says "I want kids from estates like mine to get the coaching I nearly didn't" has a legacy, and everything that follows can be tested against it.

Three questions, answered honestly, usually get there:

1

What made the difference for you? A person, a place, a chance, a piece of luck. Legacies that echo your own story are the ones that last, because you will still care about them at fifty.

2

What would you do if the money and the profile disappeared tomorrow? If the answer is "nothing", the plan depends on things you will not always have.

3

Who else would need to be true to it for it to work? Family, agent, club, sponsor. If they are part of the plan, they need to be part of the answer.

Write the sentence

THE LEGACY SENTENCE

"I want [who] to [what will be different], because [why me]." Write it, show it to two people who will tell you the truth, and rewrite it until it is specific enough to disagree with. Every decision in the rest of this guide is tested against it.

DECISION

If you cannot finish the sentence yet, stop here and spend six months finding out: volunteer, visit, listen. A structure set up before the sentence exists will shape the sentence to fit the structure, which is the wrong way round.

Who, exactly, and what do they need?

"Young people" is not a beneficiary group. It is a demographic. The difference between a legacy and a gesture is knowing precisely who you are for and what they are missing.

NEEDS ASSESSMENT IN FIVE QUESTIONS

- ☐ Who are they, specifically? Age, place, circumstance. "Girls aged 11 to 14 in the three secondary schools nearest the club" beats "young women in sport".
- ☐ What is the need, in their words? Not what you assume. Ask twenty of them, or the people who work with them every day.
- ☐ Who already serves them, and how well? The local charity, the school, the council, the governing body. Your legacy is more likely to fill a gap than to open a new front.
- ☐ What would be different for them in three years if this worked? Say it in numbers and in a sentence.
- ☐ How will you know? Decide the measure before you start, not after.

Involve them from the start

INTERPRETATION The foundations that last are the ones whose beneficiaries helped design them. It is not a courtesy; it is how you avoid building the programme you would have wanted at fourteen rather than the one that is needed now. A small advisory group of the people you aim to serve, meeting twice a year, costs nothing and prevents the most expensive mistakes.

Measure from day one

Decide three things to measure before you spend a pound: one count (how many), one change (what is different for them, before and after) and one voice (what they say about it). Keep those three for as long as the work runs. They are the evidence that will one day persuade a funder, a sponsor or a governing body to carry on what you started.

THE KEY QUESTION

If you described your beneficiaries to someone who works with them every day, would they recognise them, and would they agree about the need?

Foundation, fund, partnership or gift?

There are at least five ways to deliver a legacy, and your own registered charity is the most demanding of them. Match the vehicle to the sentence you wrote in Part 1, not to what other athletes have done.

VEHICLE	WHAT IT IS	BEST WHEN	WATCH OUT FOR
A gift to an existing charity	A donation, restricted if you wish, to a charity already serving your beneficiaries. Gift Aid adds 25p to every £1 from a UK taxpayer.	The need is already well served and the gap is money. You want impact now, not administration.	Choose the charity on evidence of results, not on who asked first. Ask to see outcomes, not brochures.
A named fund	A fund in your name held by a community foundation or a donor-advised fund provider, which handles the administration and grants out on your instructions.	You want your name on it, tax-efficient giving, local knowledge and no board of your own.	Grant-making only; it will not run programmes. Fees are modest but real.
A partnership	An ambassador or founding-partner role with an existing charity: your profile, time and network, alongside money. A named programme inside their work.	Your most valuable asset is attention rather than cash, and the delivery expertise exists elsewhere.	Agree in writing what each side gives and what success looks like. Review annually.
Your own charity	A registered charity, usually a Foundation CIO, with trustees, accounts, a regulator and a public record.	The purpose is distinct, nobody else is doing it, you are committing for ten years, and you will fund it beyond your own gifts.	Running costs, trustee time, compliance and the retirement cliff. Our structures guide covers the choices in detail.
A social enterprise	A company (often a CIC) running academies, camps or coaching commercially, giving its profits to the cause.	The activity is a business that happens to do good, and you want to be paid for running it.	Not a charity: no Gift Aid, no rates relief. Say so plainly in how it is described.

EVIDENCE In England and Wales a charity must register with the Charity Commission once its income exceeds £5,000 a year, and a Charitable Incorporated Organisation must register whatever its income. Trustees cannot be paid for being trustees. Gift Aid allows a charity to reclaim basic-rate tax on donations from UK taxpayers; higher-rate taxpayers can claim additional relief themselves. A network of community foundations covers every part of the UK and specialises in named funds for local giving.

The decision flow

Four questions, in order. Most people get their answer by the second.

Is the need already well served by a charity you trust?

YES Give, or partner. Put your name on a programme, not on a letterhead.

NO Next question.

Is what you want to do grant-making, or delivery?

GRANT-MAKING A named fund at a community foundation or a donor-advised fund does this better and cheaper than a charity of your own.

DELIVERY Next question.

Is the activity a business?

YES A company or CIC, with profits gifted to the cause. Be honest in the branding.

NO Next question.

Will you commit for ten years, govern it properly, and fund it beyond yourself?

YES TO ALL THREE Set up the charity, following Part 4.

NO TO ANY Partner first. Run a two-year programme inside an existing charity and revisit the question with evidence.

THE KEY QUESTION

Would your beneficiaries be better off if the money you would spend running a foundation went to the work instead? For a new foundation, administration, accounts, insurance, safeguarding and professional fees can absorb several thousand pounds a year before anything reaches a beneficiary. That is a fair price for the right purpose and a poor one for a gesture.

Governance that survives your retirement

A charity is not a brand extension. From the day it registers it belongs to its purposes and its beneficiaries, not to you, and the people who run it owe their duties to them. Build it that way and it will outlive your career. Build it as a fan club and it will not.

TRUSTEES

- A majority of independent trustees: people with no personal, family or business link to you. Family and agent can serve, but they should not be the board.
- Recruit for what the charity needs: someone who knows the beneficiaries, someone who knows money, someone who knows safeguarding, someone who has run a small organisation.
- A chair who is not you. Your role is founder, patron or ambassador. The chair's job is to hold the board to the purpose, including when you change your mind.

CONFLICTS OF INTEREST

- You cannot be paid by the charity for being a trustee, and payment for anything else needs authority and care.
- Your image-rights company, your sponsors and your agent are all potential conflicts. Declare them, record them, and have the unconflicted trustees decide.
- Keep the charity's money, brand and contracts separate from your commercial ones, always.

SAFEGUARDING

- If the work involves children or vulnerable adults, safeguarding is the first policy, not the last. Named lead, training, checks, a reporting route, and a board that reads the reports.
- Sport has its own history here. Expect scrutiny and welcome it.

THE NAME

- Naming the charity after yourself gives it profile now and ties its fortunes to yours forever. Naming it after the purpose or the place gives it a life of its own.
- A sensible middle path is a purpose-led name with "founded by" in the story. Decide with the trustees, not the sponsor.

THE FOUNDER'S ROLE, WRITTEN DOWN

- What you will do (appearances, introductions, an annual gift), what you will not (run it day to day), and how disagreements between you and the board are settled.

EVIDENCE The Charity Commission's guidance *The essential trustee* (CC3) sets out trustees' duties, including the duty to act in the charity's best interests and to manage conflicts of interest. Registered charities file annual returns and, above the relevant thresholds, accounts that are independently examined or audited, all on the public register.

founder, not owner →

Money that does not depend on your diary

Most athlete foundations are funded by one person and one dinner. Both stop. A legacy needs income that keeps arriving after the last appearance fee.

YOUR OWN GIFT

Decide between an annual gift and an endowment, and say which. A gift that is promised for five years, in writing, lets trustees plan. Gift Aid makes it worth 25% more.

BRAND AND SPONSOR PARTNERS

Your commercial partners may fund the legacy, especially where it fits their own social-value commitments. Agree outcomes and reporting, and keep it separate from your personal deals.

GRANTS

Trusts and foundations fund evidence, not fame. A celebrity name can make a funder more cautious, not less. Two years of results from a small programme open doors that a launch party cannot.

THE SPORT ITSELF

Clubs, governing bodies and their foundations have pathways, facilities and sometimes money. A programme they would be proud to adopt is a programme that can outlast you.

Events, honestly

INTERPRETATION A gala dinner is a marketing event with a fundraising by-product. Many raise less than they cost once staff time, venue and the free tables for sponsors are counted. Hold one if it builds relationships you need; do not build the budget on it.

The three rules

1

Two years banked before you start. Do not begin a programme for beneficiaries until the money to run it for two years is in the bank. Stopping a service for children because a sponsor left is the opposite of a legacy.

2

No single source over half. Including you. When one source is more than half the income, the charity is a hobby of that source.

3

Transparency as the default. Publish what came in, what went out and what changed. Donors, sponsors and funders give more to charities they can see into.

DECISION

Write a three-year budget with the costs of running the charity shown separately from the costs of the work. If the running costs are more than a quarter of the whole, revisit Part 3: a named fund or a partnership may deliver more of your money to the people it is for.

Prove it, and plan for the day you step back

The measure of a legacy is what carries on without you. Impact evidence is how you earn the funders and partners who will carry it, and transition planning is how you hand it over on purpose rather than by accident.

ESTABLISH CLEAR METRICS

Three measures, chosen in Part 2, collected the same way every time: a count, a change and a voice. Outputs (sessions, participants) show activity. Outcomes (confidence, skills, places on a pathway, time in education) show difference. Keep the two separate in everything you publish.

COMMUNICATE EFFECTIVELY

One honest annual report that says what you set out to do, what you did, what changed, what did not, and what you will do next. Setbacks included. Beneficiaries' words, with consent, in their own voice. This is also what the new charity reporting rules now expect of the trustees' annual report.

PLAN FOR TRANSITION

- Name the chair who will lead when you are less available, and have them lead now.
- Build income that does not need you in the room: a partner programme, a named fund, a sponsor contract tied to outcomes.
- Write the exit options into the plan from the start: merge with a larger charity, hand the programme to the governing body, or close well and give the assets on. A planned ending is a legacy; a slow fade is not.
- Agree a review point, three years in, when the trustees ask the Part 3 question again with evidence in hand.

THE TEST

If you stepped away tomorrow, would the work continue for the people it is for? If the honest answer is no, the plan is not finished, whatever the structure says.

"Building a legacy is about intentional action and authentic impact for the future."

Matthew Hickey, founder, Social Intent

How ready are you?

Ten questions. Score each 0 (not yet), 1 (partly) or 2 (yes, and I could show the evidence). Be hard on yourself; the score is only useful if it is honest.

QUESTION	0	1	2
I can say my legacy in one sentence: who, what will be different, and why me.	☐	☐	☐
I know my beneficiaries specifically, and people who work with them would agree about the need.	☐	☐	☐
I know who already serves them, and where the real gap is.	☐	☐	☐
I have chosen the vehicle (gift, fund, partnership, charity or enterprise) for reasons I can explain.	☐	☐	☐
I have tested the idea with something small and have early evidence it works.	☐	☐	☐
There are independent people around this who will tell me the truth, and one of them will chair it.	☐	☐	☐
Two years of funding is identified, and no single source (including me) is more than half.	☐	☐	☐
I know the three things we will measure, and how.	☐	☐	☐
The plan works after I retire: income, leadership and a route for the work to carry on.	☐	☐	☐
My family, agent and commercial partners understand the plan and their part in it.	☐	☐	☐
Total (out of 20)	☐	☐	☐

What your score means

0 to 7

START WITH PURPOSE

The vision needs refining before anything is built. Spend six months on Parts 1 and 2: volunteer, visit, listen, write the sentence. Give through an existing charity meanwhile, and learn from how they do it.

8 to 14

BUILD THE PLAN

The purpose is there; the structure around it is not. Run a two-year programme in partnership with an existing charity, collect the three measures, and write the three-year budget. Revisit the vehicle decision with evidence.

15 to 20

READY TO BUILD

You have a defined legacy, evidence, independent people and a funding plan. If a charity of your own is the right vehicle, set it up following Part 4 and our structures guide. If it is not, you already know what is.

INTERPRETATION Most people score between 8 and 12 the first time, and are surprised. Low scores are rarely about commitment; they are about the questions nobody asked before the paperwork started. A year later, with a partner programme behind them, the same people score 16 or more, and the structure they choose is usually not the one they first had in mind.

Sources and further reading

Charity Commission for England and Wales: *The essential trustee: what you need to know, what you need to do* (CC3); *Charity types: how to choose a structure* (CC22a); *Conflicts of interest: a guide for charity trustees* (CC29); *Safeguarding and protecting people for charities and trustees*; and *Changes to charity accounting and reporting* (2026). HMRC: Gift Aid guidance for charities and donors. UK Community Foundations: ukcommunityfoundations.org. The companion guide, *Charity structures and trading subsidiaries*, covers the legal forms in detail and is available from social-intent.com. Thresholds and figures are as published in October 2026.

Where this guide describes the pattern of athlete foundations and what funders and partners look for, that is our interpretation from thirty years in and around charities and sport, and it is labelled as such. Nothing here is legal, tax or financial advice; take professional advice on your own circumstances before you act.

Want to talk it through before you decide?

A free 30-minute call with someone who has run charities, sat on their boards, and competed. We will tell you which vehicle fits, even if the answer is "not a foundation". <https://calendly.com/social-intent/30min> · hello@social-intent.com · 0161 870 5544

no hard sell



ABOUT SOCIAL INTENT

Social Intent is a critical friend to charities and to the companies and people who back them. We help founders and boards get clear about what they are for, show the difference they make, and build the income and partnerships that follow. Its founder, Matthew Hickey, is a former elite swimmer who has been a charity chief executive, marketing director, fundraiser, trustee and adviser. Social Intent Limited is registered in England and Wales, company number 15373679. www.social-intent.com

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